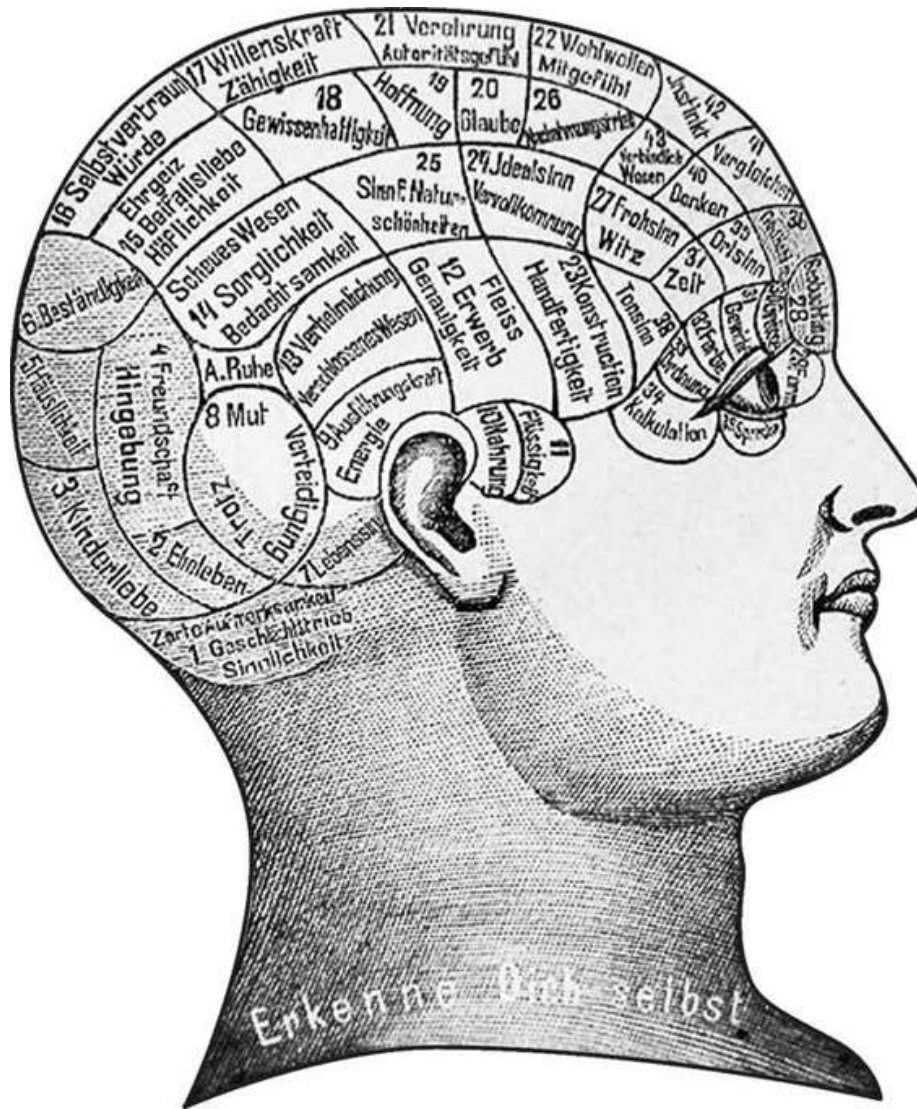


Philosophy vs psychology



William James studied medicine before he became a philosopher – a combination of subjects that led to him become a leading figure in the new science of psychology. Pragmatism, with its emphasis on things that make a difference rather than the abstract and speculative, proved complementary to the objective study of human behaviour and mental processes. James was among the first true psychologists, helping to mark the field as a scientific discipline through observation, experiments and analysis of data distinct from the pure reasoning and theorizing of philosophy. He also established the first courses in experimental psychology in the USA. In particular, he

worked on a psychological explanation of consciousness, a subject that had long occupied philosophers, but without subjecting it to rigorous scientific scrutiny. Instead, he showed that consciousness is a mental process, a way that we connect and organize our various thoughts. In describing consciousness as a continuous process, James introduced the influential notion of a 'stream of consciousness'.